WhatsApp Agent for Indian SMBs

A 30-day launch plan for a self-serve product - niche choice, offer, pricing, the tech to build, and your first 10 paying customers.

1. Executive summary

You chose a self-serve product (the SMB sets itself up) and asked me to pick the niche and write the 30-day plan. Here is the decision.

- **Niche: coaching and test-prep institutes first.** They have the sharpest, most measurable pain - during admission season a mid-size institute gets 150-400 enquiries a day, 60-80% asking the same questions, and answers them in 2-4 hours. Roughly 35-45% of those leads go cold before anyone replies. That is a number you can fix and charge for.
- **Model: self-serve, but run it 'concierge' for the first 10 customers.** Do the setup by hand for the first ten institutes, learn what actually converts, then turn those exact steps into the self-serve product. This is how you beat bigger platforms: depth in one niche, not breadth.
- **Pricing: Rs 999-4,999/month in three tiers, with Meta's message costs passed through at cost.** That undercuts Wati (Rs 2,999) and Interakt (Rs 2,799) on entry, and matches the market for a focused product.
- **30-day goal: 10 paying institutes, roughly Rs 25,000-40,000 monthly recurring revenue, and a working MVP** - not a finished product. Revenue and proof first; polish later.

One honest flag up front: a fully self-serve product is harder than a done-for-you service, because you are competing with funded platforms (AiSensy, Wati, Interakt) that already sell to Indian SMBs. The reason this can still work is the niche. Those platforms are horizontal - they sell to everyone. A coaching-only product that answers the seven questions every parent asks, books demo classes, and follows up in the counsellor's name is something they do not do well. Niche depth is your only real moat at this stage.

2. Which niche to pick

I compared the three obvious SMB niches on pain, proof, competition, and how much a customer will pay. Here is the ranking.

Rank	Niche	The pain	Price it supports	Competition
1	Coaching / test-prep institutes	150-400 enquiries a day in season; 35-45% of leads lost to slow replies	Rs 1,500-4,000/mo	Mostly done-for-you agencies; weak self-serve tools
2	Clinics & diagnostic labs	No-shows; report-status phone calls; no recall	Rs 3,000-8,000/mo	Several players (BetaXLab, Orbixel); needs HMS/LIMS integration
3	Restaurants & cloud kitchens	25-30% aggregator commission on every order	Rs 299-999/mo	Crowded and cheap (Oye Orders at Rs 299/mo)

Avoid starting with D2C / e-commerce sellers. That is exactly where Interakt and AiSensy are strongest, and they already own the niche.

3. Why coaching institutes, in one number each

Coaching is the best self-serve fit because the flows are simple (no payments, no lab reports to integrate), the ROI is obvious, and the buying trigger is seasonal and urgent. The evidence from institutes already running WhatsApp automation:

Metric	Before	After
Average first-response time	2.8 hours	8 seconds
Demo-class show-up rate	38%	69%
Post-demo conversion	18%	34%
Admissions in one season	47	141
Monthly enrolments (another case)	34	79

Seven questions account for 65-75% of all admission enquiries: fees and payment options, batch timings, demo class availability, faculty credentials, online/offline options, results, and instalments. Build a bot that answers those seven perfectly and books a demo class, and you have automated most of the workload. That is a small, well-defined product - exactly what self-serve needs.

4. The product: what the institute does (self-serve)

The promise to the customer is simple: connect your WhatsApp number, pick the coaching template, and start replying in seconds - without hiring anyone or writing code. The sign-up flow:

1. **Sign up** with a phone number or Google, and name the institute.
2. **Connect the WhatsApp Business number** via Meta's embedded signup (they scan, you handle the verification).
3. **Pick the Coaching template** - the seven FAQs, fee structure, batch list, and demo-class slots are pre-filled; they edit the text.
4. **Turn on the three core flows**: instant reply + FAQ, lead qualification (class, board, target exam, timeline), and demo-class booking with reminders.
5. **Go live** and watch enquiries land in a shared inbox, with hot leads flagged for a counsellor call.

MVP vs later

Build first (MVP)	Add later
Signup, connect WhatsApp number, one template, FAQ + qualification + demo booking, shared inbox, email alerts	14-30 day nurture sequences, counsellor CRM board, fee-reminder flows, payment links, analytics, multi-number

5. Offer and pricing

Price on value (leads not lost), not on cost. Anchor against the lost enquiry: one extra admission at Rs 85,000 annual fee pays for years of the product. Keep Meta's message charges passed through at cost - it is a trust signal that most platforms break.

Plan	Price	Includes	For
Starter	Rs 999/mo	1 number, FAQ + qualification flows, 1,000 contacts, shared inbox	Small institutes testing WhatsApp
Growth	Rs 2,499/mo	AI agent replies, demo booking + reminders, 3 users, nurture flow, lead board	Most institutes (recommended)
Pro	Rs 4,999/mo	Multi-number, payment links, CRM export, priority support, unlimited flows	Multi-branch / high-volume institutes

For your first 10 customers, do not sell the subscription alone. Offer a **concierge pilot: Rs 15,000 one-time setup, done by you in a week, then Rs 2,499/month.** This is how you get paid while you build, and it tells you exactly what the self-serve product must do. Give the first three a free 2-week pilot in exchange for a testimonial and a case-study number.

6. The system: what we will build

This is the stack I recommend, chosen so a small team can build and run it cheaply. I will write the code with you.

Layer	Choice	Why
Frontend	Next.js + Tailwind (landing page + dashboard)	Fast to build, good SEO for 'WhatsApp for coaching' searches
Backend	Python FastAPI + Postgres	Simple, handles webhooks and AI calls well
WhatsApp	Meta WhatsApp Cloud API (direct, not via a BSP)	No middleman markup; cheaper for you and the customer
AI replies	An LLM with Hindi + regional language support, fallback to scripted flows	Handles free-text questions; flows handle the predictable 70%
Flow engine	Flows defined as JSON, edited in the dashboard	Lets non-technical staff change the bot without code
Payments & billing	Razorpay subscriptions (UPI/cards)	Indian SMBs pay by UPI; recurring billing built in
Compliance	Opt-in capture, DPDP-aligned consent, Meta template approval	Required to keep the number in good standing

Biggest technical risk	Meta has tightened rules on running third-party AI chatbots over the WhatsApp Business API. Verify what is currently allowed before you rely on an LLM agent; the scripted-flow path is always safe.
Cost to run	Meta charges per message: in India roughly Rs 0.86 for marketing and Rs 0.115 for utility/auth (service replies free up to 1,000 per number per month as of now). Pass these through; do not absorb them.
What 'the system' really is	A web app + a WhatsApp webhook + a flow runner + an inbox. It is very buildable by two people in a few weeks - the hard part is the niche knowledge, not the code.

7. The 30-day plan

Week 1 - Validate and set up.

- Talk to 30 coaching institutes (in person in a coaching hub, or on call). Ask what happens to a 9pm enquiry and how many they lose.
- Register for the WhatsApp Cloud API / Business account and get one test number working.
- Build the landing page: 'WhatsApp agent for coaching institutes - reply in 8 seconds.' One page, a demo video, a signup form.
- Write the concierge offer (Rs 15,000 setup + Rs 2,499/mo) and the 7-question template.

Week 2 - Concierge MVP (get paid before you build).

- Onboard 3-5 institutes by hand: set up their number, write their FAQ text, connect their demo-class slots.
- Run the bot live for them and personally watch every conversation for a week. Note every failure.
- Collect the first payments (even Rs 15,000 setup fees). This is your proof.

Week 3 - Build the self-serve MVP.

- Turn the manual steps into the product: signup, connect number, coaching template, flow runner, shared inbox.
- Keep the AI reply limited to FAQ-type questions; route everything else to a human.
- Instrument it: count enquiries handled, leads qualified, demos booked.

Week 4 - Reach 10 paying customers.

- Onboard 5-7 more institutes (see section 8). Target 10 paying in total.
- Publish your first case study: 'Institute X went from 2-hour replies to 8 seconds and doubled demo show-ups.'
- Set your numbers: MRR, churn, messages per institute, support time per customer. Decide what to fix next month.

8. Your first 10 customers

You need 10 paying institutes. The funnel: list 150, contact all, book 20 calls, run 6 pilots, convert 10. Here is exactly where and how.

Channel	What to do
Coaching hubs	Go where institutes cluster - Kota, Delhi's Mukherjee Nagar, Hyderabad's Ameerpet, Pune. Walk in, ask for the admissions head.
Google Maps + Instagram	Search 'coaching institute' + your city; DM/WhatsApp the ones running Instagram ads (they already spend on leads).
Education expos & fairs	Set up a small booth or just walk the floor; every institute there has an admissions problem.
Referrals	One happy institute introduces the next. Ask for two names at every check-in.

The opening message (WhatsApp, short):

"Hi [Name], I help coaching institutes reply to every admission enquiry in seconds - even at 2am. Last season one institute doubled its demo-class show-ups just by answering faster. Can I show you a 2-minute demo on your own number?"

The demo is the sale: ask them to message your demo number as if they were a parent, and let them watch the bot answer, qualify, and book a demo class. Then offer the concierge pilot. Do not talk features - talk about the leads they are losing at 9pm.

9. Numbers to watch

- **MRR and paying institutes** - the only two that matter in month one. Target Rs 25,000-40,000 from 10 institutes.
- **Enquiries handled per institute** - if it is under ~200/month, the value is thin; target institutes with real volume.
- **First-response time** - your headline metric. Show it to every prospect: '8 seconds vs their 3 hours.'
- **Support time per customer** - if onboarding takes more than a few hours, the self-serve promise is broken; fix the product.
- **Gross margin** - subscription minus Meta message cost. Passing Meta costs through is what keeps this healthy.

10. Honest risks

- **Meta's rules on third-party AI bots** can change; build the scripted-flow path so you are never fully dependent on an LLM agent.

- **Template approvals and opt-in** are mandatory - a number that spams gets restricted. Build consent into signup.
- **Funded competitors** could move into coaching. Your defence is niche depth and local support, not price.
- **Self-serve support is heavy in India.** Most SMBs will still want hand-holding - which is why the concierge first 10 matters.
- **Seasonality.** Coaching demand peaks March-June. Use the off-season to build nurture flows and sell year-round value (fee reminders, parent updates).
- **You still need the niche conversation.** The code is the easy part; 30 conversations in week 1 are what decide this.

11. Sources

Figures in this plan are drawn from the following public sources (2025-2026).

- AiBotick, WhatsApp admission automation case studies (response time, admissions, demo show-up, conversion).
- WatEase, admission enquiry capture for Indian institutes (seasonal capacity, fee-revenue example).
- WhatsGrow AI and LandinChat, self-serve WhatsApp admissions products (feature and pricing benchmarks).
- BetaXLab, Go4whatsup, OrbixelLabs and NY Digital, clinic/lab WhatsApp pricing (no-show reduction, Rs 1,299/mo to Rs 41,999 setup).
- Vaanik, Oye Orders and WhatServe, restaurant/cloud-kitchen WhatsApp ordering (commission saved, Rs 299/mo benchmark).
- Gupshup INR rate card and Meta for Developers, WhatsApp per-message pricing in India (Oct 2025 / Jan 2026).
- AiSensy, Wati, Interakt public pricing pages (BSP subscription benchmarks).
- eDarpan, WhatsApp Business AI for Indian SMBs (Meta policy note on third-party AI chatbots).
- Fortune India / GoKwik, WhatsApp Commerce Intelligence Report 2026 (AI-driven WhatsApp performance).